



RENAISSANCE
PREMIER REALTY GROUP

Move with Strategy

A BONUS GUIDE · HOUSTON

The Houston Guide for Families of Neurodivergent & Disabled Kids

*Real resources, organized the way a parent actually
needs them — by neighborhood and by season.*

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YOU'RE NOT DOING THIS ALONE

Moving is hard on every kid. It's a different kind of hard when your child doesn't do well with transitions, needs a wheelchair-accessible route through the world, is managing a serious medical diagnosis, or just needs things to make a little more sense before they can enjoy them.

I'm a parent to a wonderful AuDHD little girl myself, and I built this guide because I know what it's like to walk into a new city and have no idea where the quiet room is, which museum has sensory backpacks, whether a playground actually works for your child, or who to call first if the diagnosis is bigger than autism.

This isn't a clinical resource — it's the practical, "here's what's actually here and where to find it" list I wish someone had handed me, for autism, ADHD, Down syndrome, cerebral palsy, rare conditions, cancer, and every family navigating disability of any kind. Organized by neighborhood and by season, because that's how you'll actually use it.

Wherever your family lands on that spectrum of need, this guide is for you.



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SECTION ONE

PLACES WITH REAL, YEAR-ROUND ACCOMMODATIONS

Start here — these aren't one-day events, they're places built with permanent sensory accommodations you can use any time you visit.

Houston Museum of Natural Science

A **Certified Autism Center** (staff trained through IBCCES). Has a dedicated, unstaffed **Sensory Room** in the Duncan Wing lower-level elevator lobby (beanbags, fidgets, headphones, weighted lap blanket, bubble tube) available first-come-first-served, plus checkout **Sensory Backpacks** (fidgets, ear defenders, sunglasses) and a printed **Sensory Guide** rating every exhibit hall's noise and visual stimulation level in advance.

Space Center Houston

Also a **Certified Autism Center**, equipped to accommodate visitors with autism, sensory, and cognitive differences on any regular visit, not just special events.

Children's Museum Houston

Offers **story guides** and **visual schedules** year-round to help with transitions between exhibit spaces, in addition to its scheduled sensory-friendly days covered next.

★ WHY THIS LIST STARTS HERE

Everything else in this guide is wonderful, but it's often tied to a specific day or event. These three are always there — the ones you can build a genuinely ordinary Saturday around, no advance planning required.

SECTION TWO

THE SENSORY-FRIENDLY EVENTS CALENDAR

Organized by frequency, so you can actually plan around it.

WEEKLY

AMC Theatres

First Colony, Willowbrook & Gulf Pointe. Sensory-friendly showings every Wednesday evening via their Autism Society partnership — lights up, sound down, free to move or talk.

Sky High Sports Trampoline Park

Every Tuesday: lights dimmed and distractions reduced for a dedicated sensory-friendly jump session.

MONTHLY

AMC Theatres

A second showing on the 2nd and 4th Saturday of each month.

Chuck E. Cheese

7 Houston-area locations. First Sunday of every month: reduced crowds and noise, dimmed lighting, toned-down music.

SEASONALLY (3-4×/YEAR)

Houston Museum of Natural Science

Dedicated Sensory Friendly Days; exhibits, planetarium, and giant-screen theatre all modified for the day.

Space Center Houston

Roughly four times a year, limited attendance, reduced noise and lighting.

Houston Ballet

Each season, modified lighting/sound and freedom to move during the show.

Main Street Theater

Several performances a year, with prompt books sent ahead so you can prep your child.

Hobby Center

Sensory-friendly touring Broadway performances, with prep materials sent to families in advance.

★ PUT THIS ON YOUR YEARLY CALENDAR

Autism Moms of Houston hosts a seasonal **Adaptive Egg Hunt** each spring — sensory-friendly, with moonwalks, face painting, and resources alongside the actual egg hunt. A genuinely good “meet other families like yours” event, not just an activity for your kid.

SECTION TWO · CONTINUED

IF YOUR CHILD IS BLIND, DEAF, OR USES A WHEELCHAIR

Real, recurring accommodations — not just “the building has a ramp.”

BLIND & LOW-VISION

MFAH — Art Beyond Sight

2nd Saturday monthly: verbal-description gallery tours & hands-on activities. Free, pre-register at accessibility@mfaah.org.

HMNS Touch Tours

Tactile tours with real specimens; select dates. Also partners with the ReBokeh app for on-phone contrast/zoom.

The Lighthouse of Houston

Art classes with Creating With Blind Abandon; developing a tactile “Hands to See Gallery.”

Touch Tours & Audio Description

Hobby Center offers pre-show tactile touch tours; audio-description headsets at TUTS, Hobby Center & Main Street Theater.

DEAF & HARD-OF-HEARING

TUTS

The most robust program: a full published calendar of ASL-interpreted, open-captioned & audio-described shows, bookable up to two weeks ahead.

Main Street Theater & Stages Houston

ASL shadow interpretation at Main Street; Stages offers ASL-interpreted shows with priority seating at a flat \$25 (incl. gallery access + drink).

Hobby Center

ASL interpretation upon request (two weeks’ notice), plus a dedicated TTY line.

Holocaust Museum Houston

Pre-recorded ASL video interpretation at the front desk; closed captions on all video content.

SCHOOL CO-OPS FOR DEAF & HARD-OF-HEARING STUDENTS (RDSPD)

Texas pools this low-incidence disability across districts rather than each running its own program — here’s which co-op serves your ZIP code.

NW Harris Co-op

CFISD, Spring Branch, Klein, Tomball, Waller ISDs. HS site: Cy-Ridge.

Region 4 RDSPD

Run by ESC Region 4 directly; 8+ member districts incl. HISD (Baker Montessori, Pre-K/K).

Pasadena ISD

In-house since 2018: South Belt Elem, Melillo Middle, Beverly Hills, Dobie9/Main.

West 10 RDSPD

Katy ISD hub: Katy, Bellville, Sealy, Hempstead, Royal + charters.

Tri-County East RDSPD

Goose Creek CISD, Baytown — east Harris/Chambers area.

Brazoria-Fort Bend RDSPD

Fort Bend ISD hub, 11 districts incl. Alief, Lamar CISD, Stafford.

GBCDHH

Alvin, Clear Creek, Dickinson, Friendswood, Galveston, Pearland. HS: Clear Springs.

Conroe ISD RDSPD

North side, 8-district co-op incl. Magnolia, Montgomery, Willis.

Melinda Webb School

Private, Med Center area; ages 18mo-kindergarten only, not a K-12 substitute.

WHEELCHAIR USERS & MOBILITY NEEDS

Hobby Center Access Team

Yellow-shirted volunteers at every entry, a courtesy golf cart from the garage, and on-site courtesy wheelchairs.

MFAH

Free checkout wheelchairs at the main entrance & Rienzi, motorized wheelchairs permitted, elevator access everywhere.

HMNS

Sits on the Metro Lift line, plus accessible parking on every garage level near elevators.

SECTION THREE

INCLUSIVE PLAYGROUNDS, BY PART OF TOWN

Organized by where you'll actually be living.

INNER LOOP / CENTRAL

Hermann Park — wheelchair-accessible throughout. **Eastwood Park** — a CVS/Boundless/Houston Parks Board project. **Vale-Asche Foundation Playground Without Limits** (W. Gray) — Houston's first, plus an adaptive fitness trail. **Buddy Carruth Playground for All Children** — near the METRORail on Fannin. **Dylan Park** — an inclusive playground in Houston built with input from families of kids with disabilities.

SOUTHWEST

Alief Park Playground Without Limits — Braille and sign panels, ramps and transfer systems. **Tidwell Park** — covered playground, Braille/sign panels, connecting ramps.

NORTHWEST

Matzke Park — a hill, a large boat-swing, ADA swings, a sensory garden. **James Driver All Inclusive Park** — 29 acres, sensory garden, extra-wide ramps. **Langham Creek YMCA / Miracle League Complex** — Houston's first adaptive sports complex, PlayBooster playground attached to an adaptive baseball field.

KATY CORRIDOR

Katy Play Station ("Train Park") — the state's largest playground designed for multiple-impaired and deaf children, 13,000 sq ft, full ramp/swing accessibility. **Mary Jo Peckham Park** — a Katy favorite with accessible play equipment alongside its lake and splash pad.

SOUTHEAST / PASADENA

Verne Cox Adaptive Recreations Center — train-and-horse themed, adaptive ramps and swings. **Lindsay/Lyons Park** (Atascocita) — one of two playgrounds here is fully all-inclusive, with a sensory garden for sight-impaired children. **Galaxy All-Abilities Park** (Sugar Land) — a newer, genuinely large all-abilities playground with a space theme, worth knowing if you land in Fort Bend County. **Universally Accessible Playground** (Sugar Land) — another fully accessible option in the same corridor. **Sunset Park** (Pasadena) — accessible play equipment close to Verne Cox.

SOUTH (LEAGUE CITY)

League City's Boundless all-inclusive playground — ADA equipment, shaded structure, full accessible amenities.

Wherever you land, there's a real option nearby though obviously more in some areas than in others — this is exactly the kind of detail I factor in when we talk about which neighborhood actually fits your family.

SECTION FOUR

ADAPTIVE SPORTS & RECREATION

This is the section for when your child is ready to be part of a team, not just play solo.

YMCA Adaptive Sports

Partnered with The Miracle League — baseball with “buddy” volunteers paired with each athlete. J.E. & L.E. Mabree Complex and Lake Houston YMCA in Kingwood. **Inspirity Adaptive Sports Complex** (Humble) is another dedicated adaptive sports venue worth knowing if you land in that corridor.

Little League Challenger Division

Adaptive baseball/softball, ages 4–18, with peer “buddies” on the field. Founded 1989, running nationwide including here.

City of Houston Adaptive Sports

Genuinely extensive: wheelchair power soccer, wheelchair lacrosse, Tabata Tuesday fitness, and a fully accessible heated therapy pool with zero-depth entry.

Special Olympics Greater Houston

Track meets, flag football, volleyball, bowling and more for kids and adults with intellectual disabilities.

UH Adaptive Tennis Program

Competitive tennis instruction for students with disabilities.

Spring Rollers & Achilles Houston

Spring Rollers (The Woodlands) serves that corridor specifically; Achilles Houston pairs athletes with disabilities alongside able-bodied training partners for mainstream races.

Every one of these is built around a real team and real teammates — the “buddy” model shows up again and again for a reason. It works.



SECTION FIVE

INDOOR PLAY, BUILT FOR NEURODIVERGENT KIDS

We Rock the Spectrum

An indoor gym built from the ground up for kids with neurological differences: suspended swings, crash mats and pillows, a zip line, trampolines, and sensory-based toys — in a space where you never have to say sorry for how your kid moves through the world. Multiple Houston-area locations (Memorial, Bellaire, Sugar Land), so there's likely one within reach no matter which corridor you land in.

JUST PLAIN FUN — GREAT FOR NEUROSPICY & NEUROTYPICAL KIDS ALIKE

Not every outing needs to be a sensory-specific accommodation. This is especially true if your kids are level 1 Autistic and can tolerate a bit more sensory stimulation or if their ADHD is craving just that. Plus their neurotypical siblings may appreciate a normal change of pace. Sometimes your kid just needs to run, jump, and burn off excess energy like any other kid.

Urban Air Adventure Park

10+ locations metro-wide. Wall-to-wall trampolines, Warrior obstacle course, climbing walls, a Tubes Playground for younger kids. A membership often pays for itself in as few as 6 visits/year — confirm current pricing locally.

Bounce Bounce

Trampolines, an indoor zip line, dodgeball, a foam zone, ropes course, even a soccer field — plus a dedicated kids' maze, all in standard admission.

FunBox (Copperfield)

A 20,000 sq ft bounce park built around the 2–9 age range. Ninety-minute timed sessions; walk-ins welcome. Good if you're in the Cypress/Copperfield corridor.

Katy Mills: Bungee & Rock Wall

Right in the mall's common area. The Eurobungy lets kids do real flips well off the ground — great for a kid who craves big proprioceptive input. Bundle passes typically available.

★ WORTH NOTING FOR A NEUROSPICY KID SPECIFICALLY

All four of these are loud, bright, and busy by nature — the deliberate opposite of the quiet-room places above. Some kids love that intensity; others do better right when doors open on a weekday morning, or with noise-reducing headphones in tow. You know your kid best — this section is here so you have options either way. The great thing about these play places is they'll let the parents into many of the attractions with the kids to play alongside them.

SECTION SIX

CAMPS & ONGOING PROGRAMS

Camp HALTER (HALTER Inc.)

Genuinely one of a kind in Houston: a nonprofit founded in 2001 pairing nature-based therapy and play with real ABA modalities, built around 50+ miniature horses sized specifically for young kids with special needs — the only organization in the city using mini horses this way for its lead-line program. Beyond the horses, HALTER also works with goats, rabbits, cats, sheep, and other farm animals, runs actual autism-specific ABA programming on-site, and has partnered with local OT clinics and the Westview School for Autism. Feels less like a clinical service and more like a retreat your kid gets to visit.

Camp For All

A genuinely well-regarded camp built specifically for children and adults with challenging illnesses or special needs.

Camp Buckaroo

Week-long camp for children with disabilities ages 6–15 and their siblings, with a 1:1 volunteer-to-camper ratio.

The River Performing and Visual Arts

Inclusive youth summer camps plus year-round Saturday programming.



SECTION SEVEN

FINDING YOUR PEOPLE

This might be the most important section in the whole guide. You are not doing this alone, and Houston has a real, active community.

Autism Moms of Houston

10,000+ member nonprofit community across the whole metro; real in-person events, not just an online group.

Autism Dads Social Club

Houston chapter of the Autism Society of Texas, built specifically for dads, with its own holiday traditions.

Houston Autism Resources and Support

Active local meetup group.

Katy Autism Support & Pearland Autism Connection

Your local group if you land in either the Katy or Pearland/southeast corridor specifically.

Texas Parent to Parent

Statewide peer-support matching — connects you directly with another parent whose child has a similar diagnosis, one-on-one.

Autism Society of Texas — SE Houston Connection Group

Regional group focused on real relationships and local resource-sharing, not just meetings.

See also Section 8 — **The Arc of Harris County** runs its own parent support groups plus a genuinely valuable respite program (real supervised weekends off, not just a nice idea) alongside its education advocacy work.



SECTION SEVEN • CONTINUED

BEYOND AUTISM: DOWN SYNDROME, CP & RARE CONDITIONS

DOWN SYNDROME

Down Syndrome Association of Houston (DSAH)

Founded 1974, one of the longest-running disability support orgs in the city. Referrals, education, advocacy. (713) 682-7237, info@dsah.org

Gigi's Playhouse

Free therapeutic and educational programming — motor skills, literacy, cooking, social skills — prenatal through adulthood. Houston & Sugar Land.

Down Syndrome Diagnosis Network

National, but especially valuable in the earliest days after a prenatal or postnatal diagnosis.

CEREBRAL PALSY

United Cerebral Palsy (UCP)

National affiliate network offering therapy, resources, and advocacy for individuals with CP.

Cerebral Palsy Support Services

UCP affiliates often serve CP, autism, Down syndrome, spina bifida & epilepsy under one roof — call even if CP isn't a perfect match.

RARE & GENETIC CONDITIONS

Many families never find a single disease-specific organization for their child's diagnosis — a genuinely common, isolating experience worth naming directly.

NORD

Searchable database, can connect you even for genuinely obscure diagnoses.

Texas Parent to Parent

Matches on shared experience navigating the system, not a common diagnosis.

Texas Council for Developmental Disabilities

Statewide advocacy and resource navigation, no diagnosis category required.

★ A BROADER RESOURCE HUB WORTH BOOKMARKING

The **University of Houston's Parent Education Project (PEP)** maintains an actively updated master resource list spanning Down syndrome, cerebral palsy, sickle cell, rare genetic conditions, craniofacial conditions, deaf/hard-of-hearing services, and more — a good single bookmark when your child's specific diagnosis isn't neatly covered above.

SECTION EIGHT

SCHOOL, TUTORING & ADVOCACY: “THE SCHOOL HAS TO SERVE THEM” IS ONLY HALF THE STORY

Public schools are legally required to provide an IEP (Individualized Educational Program) and appropriate services under IDEA (The Individuals with Disabilities Education Act) that you go over with the school's Admission, Review, and Dismissal (ARD) committee. What that doesn't guarantee is that you'll know how to ask for the right things, or that every district delivers services with the same depth. Unlike general academics, Texas has no public accountability rating for special education quality — there's no GreatSchools-style score to look up. **Katy ISD** comes up repeatedly in parent conversations for special education specifically, but treat any district's reputation as a starting point, not a guarantee.

PRIVATE SCHOOLS BUILT SPECIFICALLY FOR LEARNING DIFFERENCES

The Briarwood School (K-12)

Houston's premier school for dyslexia, dysgraphia, dyscalculia. Diagnostic-prescriptive instruction, classes averaging 6 students.

The Joy School (K-8)

Nonsectarian, for intellectually capable kids with dyslexia, dysgraphia, dyscalculia, ADHD, and language disorders.

The Parish School

Therapy built into the classroom itself — up to 15 hrs/week group language therapy, nature-based campus, 5:1 student-adult ratio. Strong for autism, ADHD, speech delays.

Gateway Academy (6-12)

Nonprofit for social & learning differences: autism, ADHD, anxiety, dyslexia. Also runs a post-high-school bridge program.

The Westview School & Avondale House

Both autism-specific. Westview builds in OT, speech, and behavior support; Avondale is frequently cited for staff dedication.

The Arbor School

Small classes, uses music and art therapy alongside academics to build cognitive function.

Excelsior Academy

ADHD-specific, under 10 students per class, multi-sensory and kinesthetic-friendly.

Fusion Academy

Genuinely 1-to-1: one teacher, one student, fully customized pacing.

The Rise School of Houston

Early-childhood school where ~75% of students have Down syndrome and 25% have other developmental disabilities. The clearest not-autism-specific option here.



SECTION EIGHT · CONTINUED

PUBLIC OPTIONS & SPECIALIZED TUTORING

PUBLIC & CHARTER OPTIONS WORTH KNOWING

Katy ISD

Comes up most often in parent word-of-mouth for special education specifically — confirm current services directly rather than relying on reputation alone.

HCDE Academic and Behavior Schools

ABS East and West serve students with multiple disabilities or significant behavioral/intellectual needs, accessed through referral from your home district.

SPEDTex

The Texas Education Agency's own official resource hub for families navigating special education statewide — a good first stop for understanding your actual rights before you're in a meeting, and it also publishes homeschool-specific guidance for families providing special education services themselves.

HOMESCHOOLING WITH A SPECIAL-NEEDS CURRICULUM

Special-Needs Homeschool Co-ops

Often organized informally, e.g. via Facebook groups like Special Needs Homeschool Group of Houston. Connect families using structured curricula — Orton-Gillingham-based reading, ABA-adjacent behavior supports — plus a social group along the way.

Texas Virtual Academy & Other Open-Enrollment Charters

IEP-eligible virtual schooling, letting some families homeschool while retaining public special-education services.

SPECIALIZED TUTORING APPROACHES WORTH ASKING ABOUT BY NAME

Orton-Gillingham & Wilson

The gold-standard multisensory approach for dyslexia and reading intervention; Wilson is its structured variant.

Lindamood-Bell & Visualizing/Verbalizing

Research-based reading and language comprehension methods (including the LIPS program), often used together.

Independent Educational Therapists

Combine these approaches with formal evaluation (WIAT-4 and similar achievement testing) to pinpoint exactly where a child's gaps are — worth seeking out if your child's school-based evaluation felt thin or inconclusive.

★ THE HONEST CAVEAT

The TEA's own SPEARS database isn't actually accessible to the public. What exists instead is parent word-of-mouth. Ask to meet the special education team and understand actual services before you commit to a neighborhood based on a district's name alone — something I can help you dig into when we talk.

SECTION EIGHT • CONTINUED

YOUR ADVOCACY RESOURCES (THE PART MOST PARENTS DON'T KNOW EXISTS)

The Arc of Harris County

Genuinely a full-service organization: free **Educational Advocacy** review of evaluations, IEPs, and 504 plans (civil-rights based plans meant to remove barriers to learning), plus attending **one ARD/IEP meeting a year** with you to model advocacy in real time. A **Weekend Respite** program runs two weekends a month (Friday evening–Saturday afternoon) out of a dedicated respite house with The Harris Center — real supervised time off, not a platitude. Also: monthly dances, community outings, a week-long overnight summer camp, supervised adult vacations, ongoing parent support groups, and legislative advocacy through The Arc of Texas. Membership-based, founded 1984 — worth reaching out to early.

Partners Resource Network

Free statewide workshops plus 1-on-1 help preparing for special education processes — the one to know before your first IEP meeting.

Texas Parent to Parent

The same peer-mentor matching from Section 7, but their network extends to IEP support too.

Private Advocates & Diagnosticians

Worth hiring if the school denies an evaluation or services aren't working. A paid advocate resolves most situations before they need an attorney.

Texas SSES

An underused TEA program: a one-time online account for tutoring/therapy. Accepting funds does not waive your IDEA rights.



SECTION NINE

IF YOUR CHILD IS UNDER 3, START HERE FIRST

If your child is between birth and 36 months and you have any concern at all about their development, this might be the single most important resource in this entire guide, and it's worth knowing about before anything else.

Early Childhood Intervention (ECI)

A statewide Texas program — not a Houston-specific nonprofit, an actual state program — for infants and toddlers with developmental delays, disabilities, or certain medical diagnoses.

Anyone can make a referral — you, your pediatrician, a daycare provider. No physician referral required. ECI's own guidance actively discourages "wait and see" — if you're noticing something, that's reason enough to request an evaluation. **Services come to you** — home, childcare center, a park, or telehealth. **It's genuinely affordable, often free** — sliding-fee scale, accepts Medicaid and CHIP, no child turned away for inability to pay. The team is real and multidisciplinary: speech-language pathologists, OTs, PTs, and early intervention specialists, coordinated by a dedicated service coordinator.

★ LOCALLY

The Harris Center for Mental Health and IDD runs ECI services locally (713-970-4800). They also proactively plan the transition out of ECI as your child approaches age 3 — moving your family toward public school special education, Head Start, or whatever's the right next step, so there's no service gap. If your child is already past 3, this exact window has closed, but the same urgency applies to requesting a special education evaluation through your local school district instead — don't wait there either.



SECTION TEN

SIBLING SUPPORT

It's not just your neurodivergent kid who needs a community. Brothers and sisters carry real, specific emotional weight of their own — pride, love, and occasional isolation, jealousy, grief, or confusion, often all at once — and there's a whole support model built specifically for them.

Sibshops

Sibshops is the actual name of a national model, and Houston has a real local chapter: **Project Joy and Hope** runs Sibshop on the second Saturday of each month, for siblings ages 8–13, led by trained facilitators (including “junior facilitators” who are older siblings themselves). It's built to feel like a party, not a support group — games, crafts, and activities — while still giving siblings space to talk honestly with peers who genuinely understand what it's like to have a brother or sister with a disability.

Call (713) 944-6569 or apply online. If you have more than one child, this is genuinely one of the easiest ways to make sure everyone in the family feels seen.



SECTION ELEVEN

SENSORY-FRIENDLY DENTAL CARE, SPREAD ACROSS TOWN

A dental visit or doctor's appointment can be one of the hardest environments for a sensory-sensitive kid — bright lights, unfamiliar sounds, unavoidable touch. It's scary even for neurotypical kids, but for neurospicy kids it's extra scary. Several Houston-area pediatric dentists have built their practices specifically around this.

Memorial Children's Dentistry

The dentist herself is a mother of a child with Autism Spectrum Disorder, which shows in the practice's approach; sedation options available.

Kidzone Dental (Missouri City)

Specializes specifically in Down syndrome, autism, ADHD, and other conditions requiring adapted care.

Dental Clinics of Texas

West Houston, Cypress & Katy. Dimmed lighting, sunglasses, and noise-canceling headphones as standard; accepts Medicaid.

Lakewood Kids Dentistry

Cypress, Tomball, Spring, Jersey Village & the greater NW corridor. Sensory-friendly from the ground up, sedation options when needed.

My Tooth Fairy's

Another autism-friendly Houston practice worth knowing about.

Between these five, there's genuinely a sensory-friendly dental option within reach no matter which part of the metro you land in — worth calling ahead of your child's very first visit rather than discovering the hard way that a standard practice isn't going to work.



SECTION ELEVEN • CONTINUED

AND ON THE MEDICAL SIDE

Texas Children's — The Meyer Center for Developmental Pediatrics and Autism

The major medical program in the city, worth knowing about specifically. Primarily a diagnostic and evaluation center, not ongoing treatment — psychologists and developmental pediatricians provide formal ASD diagnosis and individualized care plans for children under 12, using a “Road Map Model”: from your very first contact, you're invited into educational workshops connecting you with community resources before you even have a formal diagnosis in hand. After evaluation, they refer out to Texas Children's broader network (speech-language pathology, OT/PT, audiology, medical subspecialists) for actual ongoing therapy.

Texas Children's — Down Syndrome Clinic & Baylor Transition Medicine

The direct parallel to the Meyer Center, but for Down syndrome specifically — comprehensive care focused on healthy development. **Baylor Transition Medicine Clinic at The Center for Pursuit** builds wrap-around healthcare for the transition into adulthood for individuals with Down syndrome and related conditions — worth knowing about even while your child is young, since this period is notoriously under-resourced almost everywhere.

Little Spurs Pediatric Urgent Care

A genuinely practical everyday option: multiple Houston-area locations, Certified Autism Center™ designation, visual schedules posted throughout the clinic, sensory toys on hand, dimmed lighting, fully trained staff, no appointment necessary, open 7 days a week. The one to know for ordinary “my kid is sick and needs to be seen today” moments, not just specialized evaluation.

Pediatrix Primary + Urgent Care of Texas

Channelview and Brookhollow locations — newer clinics genuinely designed from the ground up with autism-friendly exam rooms, kid-friendly wayfinding, and furniture sized for comfort at every age.

Nexus Children's Hospital – Houston (Westchase)

Worth knowing about for more significant needs: structured inpatient care for children ages 4–18 with severe autism or other intellectual/developmental disabilities, including a dedicated New Directions Program for kids with co-occurring medical needs. A quiet, home-like residential setting rather than a typical hospital environment — a different tier of care than routine pediatrics, relevant if your family's situation is more complex, not a first stop for typical needs.

★ STILL HAVEN'T FOUND THE RIGHT FIT?

Beaming Health's Houston directory is a genuinely useful tool rather than a single provider: an online, insurance-covered directory specifically curating sensory-friendly and autism-experienced pediatricians across the city.

SECTION ELEVEN • CONTINUED

IF YOUR CHILD HAS CANCER OR A SERIOUS ILLNESS

A different kind of need than most of this guide, and Houston is genuinely one of the strongest places in the country to be for this.

WHERE KIDS ARE ACTUALLY TREATED

Texas Children's Cancer and Hematology Center

The #1 pediatric cancer center in Texas, treating kids from all 50 states and 56+ countries. Faculty at Baylor College of Medicine.

Kinder Children's Cancer Center

A joint venture between Texas Children's and MD Anderson, combining both institutions' clinical trial access under one roof.

Children's Memorial Hermann Hospital

UTHealth/McGovern-affiliated pediatric cancer program — a good second option. (713) 704-5957 or (713) 704-KIDS.

St. Jude Children's Research Hospital

Not local (Memphis) and requires physician referral, but no family is ever billed for treatment, travel, housing, or food. Your Houston team would raise this if it fits.

SUPPORT WHILE YOU'RE THERE

Ronald McDonald House Charities Greater Houston

4 TMC locations (Holcombe House + Houses/Family Rooms at Texas Children's, Memorial Hermann & MD Anderson) — 111 bedrooms, 15 Family Lounges. Suggested \$25/night, but no family turned away.

Make-A-Wish Texas Gulf Coast & Louisiana

12,300+ wishes since 1984. Ages 2½–18 with a life-threatening condition. Don't wait to refer — 1,100+ children are currently waiting.

Children's Miracle Network

Not a separate place — the fundraising network behind Texas Children's own equipment, research, and financial assistance for families. Ask your care team directly.

Shriners Children's — Texas (Galveston)

Historic focus is orthopedics/burns/craniofacial, not primarily cancer — but all care is free regardless of ability to pay, with its own on-site Ronald McDonald House.

The honest bottom line: any pediatrician can refer directly into Texas Children's or Children's Memorial Hermann — you don't need to research St. Jude or Shriners eligibility yourself first. Those become relevant only if your local team identifies a specific reason to look further.



SECTION TWELVE

ADAPTIVE EQUIPMENT & ASSISTIVE TECHNOLOGY

Somewhere between the diagnosis and the daily reality, almost every family eventually runs into the same wall: my kid needs a piece of equipment, and I have no idea where to find it, whether insurance covers it, or whether I really have to pay full price. Texas actually has more here than most states — you just have to know where to look.

Start Here: TTAP (Texas Technology Access Program)

The single best starting point in this whole section, and genuinely underused. A **statewide device loan library** lets you borrow real assistive technology — communication devices, computer access tools, mobility aids — for **35 days**, shipped free both ways, before you spend a dollar. **26 demonstration centers** across Texas let you try devices in person (virtual demos too), plus recycle/reuse programs and financing referrals. (512) 232-0740 or toll-free (800) 828-7839
 • ttap.disabilitystudies.utexas.edu

HOUSTON'S EQUIPMENT REUSE CLUSTER

RSVP

Refurbishes and redistributes wheelchairs, walkers, standing frames, bathroom equipment. (713) 974-4621

Medcy.org

Thrift-model DME (Durable Medical Equipment) provider, free donation pickup within city limits. (832) 795-8689

Carrie's Heart

Complex rehab equipment (wheelchairs, standing frames, bathroom aids) based on available storage.

Living Hope Wheelchair Assoc.

Monthly distribution of DME and supplies. (281) 764-6251

Easter Seals / BridgingApps

Bellaire, Woodlands & Stafford: AT demos, workshops, formal evaluations. Bellaire: (713) 838-9050

Discover Technology

Donated, refurbished computer hardware/software for low-income individuals. (713) 885-1519

Beyond Houston: **Project MEND** (San Antonio) offers long-term equipment loans; **DME Exchange of Dallas** and **AGE of Central Texas** are regional options worth knowing if you travel or have family elsewhere in the state.



SECTION TWELVE · CONTINUED

COMMUNICATION, SENSORY & HOME ACCESSIBILITY

COMMUNICATION (AUGMENTATIVE & ALTERNATIVE COMMUNICATION — AAC)

The Path to Get One

(1) Get a formal AAC evaluation from an SLP with a medical-necessity letter. (2) If your child has an IEP, request an Assistive Technology evaluation in writing — schools cannot legally delay giving your child what's specified in their IEP while waiting on insurance. (3) Bill private insurance first; Medicaid is generally the payer of last resort.

Device Makers & Grants

PRC-Salttillo and Lingraphica are established speech-generating device makers with dedicated funding-support teams. If insurance falls through: United Healthcare Children's Foundation, Orange Effect Foundation, Small Steps in Speech, Autism Care Today, and The Jordan Fund all offer grants built for exactly this gap.

SENSORY SUPPORTS

A referral to an **occupational therapist** is usually the more useful move than a generic online purchase — they can recommend the right weighted-blanket weight, compression level, or seating option for your child's specific profile. If your child has an IEP or 504 plan, sensory supports used at school can often be written into the plan and provided by the district rather than purchased out of pocket. Ask your case manager directly.

HOME ACCESSIBILITY & VEHICLE MODIFICATIONS

Amy Young Barrier Removal Program

Texas Dept. of Housing and Community Affairs. One-time grants up to \$20,000 for accessibility home modifications — not tied to a Medicaid waiver.

What It Actually Covers

Stair lifts, wheelchair ramps, widened doorways, roll-in showers, grab bars, lowered countertops/cabinets, and lever-style door handles — the everyday mods that make a home usable.

Texas Foundations Fund / Home Repair Program

Funds nonprofits carrying out similar work for very low-income homeowners. Bigger-ticket modifications are usually covered through the Medicaid waivers on the next page.

★ YOUR RIGHTS ON SCHOOL EQUIPMENT

A school **cannot** make your family use private insurance to acquire AAC or other assistive technology, and if it's written into your child's IEP, the school **cannot delay** giving your child access while waiting on an insurance or Medicaid decision. If a school says funding needs to be resolved first, push back — or loop in The Arc of Harris County or Partners Resource Network from Section 8.

SECTION TWELVE · CONTINUED

TEXAS MEDICAID WAIVERS: THE REAL BACKBONE

Texas runs several waivers covering adaptive aids, home modifications, and vehicle modifications well beyond standard Medicaid. Every one has a real waitlist — **170,000+ Texans are currently waiting**, some over a decade — so apply the moment you suspect you might need one, not once you're sure. You can leave a waitlist later; you can't retroactively join one from years ago.

WAIVER	WHO IT'S FOR	KEY COVERAGE
CLASS	Disability (non-ID) originating before age 22	Adaptive aids to \$10K/yr (w/ dental); home mods to \$10K lifetime
HCS	Intellectual disability / related condition	Adaptive aids, accessible home mods, OT/PT/speech. Houston: (713) 970-7799
TxHmL	Similar to HCS, living in own/family home	Home mods capped at \$7,500 lifetime + \$300/yr repair after
MDCP	Medically fragile/tech-dependent, ages 0–20	Based on child's income only — parent income not counted
DBMD	Deaf-blind with multiple disabilities	Detailed adaptive aids/vehicle mods list, GPS & TTY/TDD devices

How to apply: CLASS, DBMD, MDCP, and STAR+PLUS HCBS can be joined online. For HCS and TxHmL, you must call your **Local IDD Authority (LIDDA)** directly. The Arc of Texas has a video walkthrough on crisis diversion waivers if your situation is urgent rather than something that can wait years.

★ NATIONAL GRANTS WORTH KNOWING

United Healthcare Children's Foundation (16 and under), Orange Effect Foundation (up to age 21), Small Steps in Speech, Autism Care Today, The Jordan Fund, and HealthWell Foundation (copays, deductibles, travel). Several of these are stackable — you're not limited to picking just one.



SECTION TWELVE · CONTINUED

TURNING 18 IN TEXAS: GUARDIANSHIP & ALTERNATIVES

The day your child turns 18, your automatic authority as a parent ends — even if they've never made a medical or financial decision independently. Entirely preventable with the right planning done early.

ALTERNATIVES, LIGHTEST-TOUCH TO MOST INVOLVED

Supported Decision-Making Agreement

Your adult child keeps full legal authority; you're named a supporter. Low-cost, often free.

Medical/Financial POA

Your child can execute these at 18 (if capable) to authorize you directly, no court process.

HIPAA Release

Simple fix for a doctor's office refusing to discuss your adult child's care with you.

SSI Representative Payee

Manage your child's SSI funds specifically, without a broader guardianship.

Limited Guardianship

Texas courts prefer this — only the specific powers needed (e.g. medical OR financial).

Full Guardianship

Reserved for when a child can't participate meaningfully in decisions even with support.

THE PROCESS, IF GUARDIANSHIP FITS

Can't file before 18, but Texas allows filing up to ~180 days ahead so the order takes effect on the birthday. Start finding an attorney around 17.

A Physician's Certificate (PCME) is required, plus a court-appointed attorney ad litem representing your child's own interests.

Timeline: budget 3–6 months end-to-end. Cost: roughly \$2,000–\$10,000+ depending on county and complexity.

Ongoing, not one-and-done: a guardian of the estate must file annual accountings with the court.

Missed the window? If your child turns 18 without anything in place, you're not locked out — you can still pursue guardianship or alternatives afterward. Treat it as urgent, not "someday." This timeline also surfaces SSI eligibility, special needs trusts/ABLE accounts, and co-parenting decisions about who pursues guardianship.



SECTION TWELVE • CONTINUED

VEHICLES, BEDS, BATHING & LIFT EQUIPMENT — WHAT’S ACTUALLY FUNDABLE

Wheelchair-Accessible Vans

Houston Children's Charity — Chariots for Children has awarded 500+ free accessible vans to Houston families since 1996. Apply at houstonchildrenscharity.org. NMEDA is the hub for modifying an existing vehicle.

Specialty & Safety Beds

Insurance/Medicaid as DME is the primary path when a physician documents medical necessity. **First Hand Foundation** also funds equipment insurance won't cover.

Bathing & Bathroom Mods

Texas Health Steps-CCP first (standard Medicaid DME, no waiver caps). **STAR Kids MDCP** home mods benefit: \$7,500 lifetime. Amy Young Barrier Removal also covers accessible showers up to \$22,500.

Hoyer / Patient Lifts

Check Texas Health Steps-CCP first. STAR Kids MDCP adaptive-aids benefit (\$4,000/yr) names lifts explicitly. CLASS waiver is a separate track if it fits your child's diagnosis.

THE MEDICAID HIERARCHY WORTH UNDERSTANDING ONCE

1. Texas Health Steps-CCP (standard Medicaid DME, kids under 21) comes first — broader coverage, no tight annual caps. 2. STAR Kids/MDCP is next: Adaptive Aids (\$4,000/yr) + Minor Home Mods (\$7,500 lifetime), both after state-plan Medicaid is exhausted. 3. CLASS waiver is a separate track for qualifying diagnoses. 4. Your MCO service coordinator is the actual gatekeeper — ask by name for both benefits.

Stair access is the least reliably covered category here — treat stairlifts as “ask, don't assume” with your MDCP coordinator rather than a guaranteed benefit.



SECTION TWELVE • CONTINUED

HURRICANE & EMERGENCY PREP FOR MEDICALLY FRAGILE KIDS

Meant to be read on a calm, sunny day in May — and acted on before June 1.

REGISTER NOW — FREE, USELESS IF YOU WAIT

STEAR

State of Texas Emergency Assistance Registry. stear.texas.gov or 2-1-1. Puts your needs in front of planners before a disaster. Renew yearly.

AlertHouston / Ready Harris

Everbridge app or readyharris.org for ZIP-specific alerts and evacuation zone status.

CenterPoint Critical Care Status

For electrically-powered medical equipment. Advance outage notifications — not a guarantee power stays on. Apply via centerpointenergy.com.

PUC Disconnection Protection

Same application as Critical Care: your REP can't disconnect for nonpayment once confirmed, with a 63-day protection window and 21-day written notice requirement.

BACKUP POWER, DEVICE BY DEVICE

Ventilators

Internal battery will run out — keep a manual Ambu bag, and make sure every caregiver knows how to use it.

Oxygen Concentrators

Ask your supplier for backup tanks that need no electricity; know your child's flow rate to calculate tank duration.

Feeding Pumps

Bolus (syringe) feeds need no power; gravity-drip bags or a DC-to-AC inverter can back up continuous feeds.

Generators must sit outdoors, 20+ feet from doors/windows/vents — carbon monoxide risk is real and fast. A portable power station is safer for apartments/townhomes. Loop in your DME supplier and physician before hurricane season, not during it.



SECTION TWELVE · CONTINUED

GETTING A GENERATOR, EVACUATING & YOUR EMERGENCY FILE

GENERATORS & BACKUP POWER — THE HONEST PICTURE

FEMA Individual Assistance Only opens after a federal disaster declaration for your county — can reimburse a generator needed for medical equipment. Apply at disasterassistance.gov.	No Individual-Home Program Exists The Texas Backup Power Package & Houston Power Protection Initiative fund facilities (hospitals, community centers), not homes. Check your own city/MUD — some, like La Porte, offer up to \$5,000.
30% Federal Tax Credit Applies to home battery storage 3 kWh+ — real money back if a battery system is already on your radar.	Know Your Multiservice Center Houston's 13 multiservice centers are being equipped with generators as public locations during an outage — know the one closest to you.

EVACUATION & YOUR EMERGENCY FILE

METROLift & Medical-Needs Shelters METROLift has moved medically vulnerable riders through past storms; STEAR registration flags your household in advance. Standard shelters usually can't support ventilators, IV meds, or dialysis — ask your OEM about medical-needs shelters.	One-Page Medical Summary Diagnosis, meds/dosages, allergies, device model numbers, physician/DME contacts — kept on paper and on your phone. A medical ID bracelet matters most if you're separated.
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How I'd actually use this: do the registrations (STEAR, AlertHouston, CenterPoint Critical Care) this week regardless of the calendar — twenty minutes total. Then build the device inventory and talk to your DME supplier before the first named storm of the season.



SECTION THIRTEEN

ACRONYM GLOSSARY

This guide throws around a lot of letters. Here's what they all actually mean, in one place.

ADA — Americans with Disabilities Act. Federal civil rights law prohibiting disability discrimination.

ASD — Autism Spectrum Disorder. Affects communication, sensory processing, social interaction.

AAC — Augmentative and Alternative Communication. Supplements or replaces spoken language.

ARD (Texas) — Admission, Review, and Dismissal Committee. Develops and reviews a student's IEP.

BCBA — Board Certified Behavior Analyst. Assesses behavior, oversees intervention programs.

DME — Durable Medical Equipment. Wheelchairs, walkers, adaptive seating, hospital beds.

ECI — Early Childhood Intervention. Texas developmental services, birth through age 3.

IDEA — Individuals with Disabilities Education Act. Federal special-education law.

Medicaid Waiver — Programs extending services beyond standard Medicaid (CLASS, HCS, MDCP, DBMD).

OT — Occupational Therapy. Skills for daily living, play, self-care, sensory regulation.

PT — Physical Therapy. Improves strength, mobility, balance, coordination.

Section 504 — Rehabilitation Act protection against discrimination; school accommodations.

SSI — Supplemental Security Income. Federal assistance for eligible disabled children/adults.

TWC — Texas Workforce Commission. Vocational rehab, employment, transition programs.

ADHD — Attention-Deficit/Hyperactivity Disorder. Affects attention, executive function, impulse control.

AuDHD — Common (non-clinical) term for someone who is both autistic and has ADHD.

ABA — Applied Behavior Analysis. Teaches skills/reduces behaviors via reinforcement; approaches vary.

AT — Assistive Technology. Devices/software helping independence with daily tasks.

CHIP — Children's Health Insurance Program. Coverage for kids above Medicaid income limits.

DSP — Direct Support Professional. Assists with daily living, employment, community life.

FAPE — Free Appropriate Public Education. Legal right under IDEA to tailored, no-cost services.

IEP — Individualized Education Program. Legally binding plan of services and goals.

MDCP — Medically Dependent Children Program. Texas waiver for medically fragile children.

PCP — Primary Care Provider. Coordinates a child's overall medical care.

RBT — Registered Behavior Technician. Delivers behavior therapy under BCBA supervision.

SLP — Speech-Language Pathologist. Treats speech, language, feeding, communication.

TEA — Texas Education Agency. Oversees public education statewide.



SECTION THIRTEEN · CONTINUED

TEXAS & MEDICAID WAIVER ACRONYMS

MEDICAID WAIVER ACRONYMS

CLASS — Community Living Assistance and Support Services	DBMD — Deaf Blind with Multiple Disabilities
HCS — Home and Community-based Services	MDCP — Medically Dependent Children Program
STAR Kids — Managed care for children with disabilities & complex medical needs	YES — Youth Empowerment Services

A FEW MORE WORTH KNOWING

IDD — Intellectual and Developmental Disabilities	LIDDA — Local Intellectual and Developmental Disability Authority
HHSC — Texas Health and Human Services Commission	CMS — Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services
SSDI — Social Security Disability Insurance	

Keep this glossary handy — you’ll hear most of these terms in your very first ARD meeting, IEP conversation, or waiver phone call, often all in the same breath.



SECTION THIRTEEN · CONTINUED

GLOSSARY, CONTINUED

A few more acronyms that came up in the later sections of this guide.

RDSPD — Regional Day School Program for the Deaf. The co-op model Texas uses to pool deaf/hard-of-hearing services across districts.

IBCCES — International Board of Credentialing and Continuing Education Standards, the body that certifies venues as Certified Autism Centers.

HCDE — Harris County Department of Education, which runs the ABS schools.

SPEARS — TEA's internal special education data system; not accessible to the public.

WIAT — Wechsler Individual Achievement Test, a formal academic achievement evaluation.

HCBS — Home and Community-Based Services, the broader Medicaid waiver category covering programs like STAR+PLUS.

HIPAA — Health Insurance Portability and Accountability Act; a HIPAA release lets a provider discuss care with someone besides the patient.

SDMA — Supported Decision-Making Agreement, a Texas-specific alternative to guardianship.

MCO — Managed Care Organization, the company administering your child's Medicaid benefits.

EPSDT — Early and Periodic Screening, Diagnosis, and Treatment, the federal Medicaid protection giving children broader coverage than adults.

UPS — Uninterruptible Power Supply, a battery backup device for electronics.

REP — Retail Electric Provider, the company you pay for electricity (distinct from CenterPoint, which delivers it).

FEMA — Federal Emergency Management Agency.

PUC — (Texas) Public Utility Commission, whose rules protect Critical Care customers from disconnection.

ISD — Independent School District, the standard name for a Texas public school district (e.g. Katy ISD).

NORD — National Organization for Rare Disorders.

ABS — Academic and Behavior Schools, HCDE's public option for students with multiple disabilities or significant behavioral/intellectual needs.

SSES — Supplemental Special Education Services, a TEA program funding extra tutoring/therapy.

TTAP — Texas Technology Access Program.

POA — Power of Attorney (medical or financial).

PCME — Physician's Certificate of Medical Examination, required medical documentation for a Texas guardianship case.

NMEDA — National Mobility Equipment Dealers Association, the certifying body for accessible-vehicle dealers.

CCP — Comprehensive Care Program (Texas Health Steps-CCP), the standard Medicaid DME benefit for kids under 21.

BiPAP — Bi-level Positive Airway Pressure, a breathing support device similar to CPAP.

OEM — Office of Emergency Management, the city/county body coordinating disaster response.

STEAR — State of Texas Emergency Assistance Registry.

TMC — Texas Medical Center.





YOU DON'T HAVE TO FIGURE THIS OUT ALONE

“Wherever you land in Houston, you don’t have to figure this out alone — I didn’t, and you shouldn’t either. If you want to talk through which neighborhood actually fits your family’s specific needs, I’m one call away, and I mean that as a fellow parent as much as as your Realtor®.”

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